

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Peninsular India: Pallavas, Chalukyas & Brahmanization - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Peninsular India c. AD 300-900

Chronology and evidence spine



Evidence hierarchy

1. Grants and inscriptions for rulers, titles and locality.
2. Architecture for patronage, sacred geography and technical shifts.
3. Literary texts for court culture and sectarian competition.
4. Use [LIMIT] whenever a source is eulogistic, compiled later or regionally thin.

Three memory anchors

Kanchi - Pallava capital, literature, structural temples.
Vatapi/Badami - Chalukya capital and cave complex.
Aihole-Pattadakal - inscription plus architectural experimentation and comparison.

Exam discipline

Separate core rule, campaign claim and later afterlife.
Do not project later Chola sabha machinery backward.
Do not turn maritime link into overseas empire.

Schematic learning visual - not to scale / not a literal cartographic claim

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQ 01

Which source most directly frames Pulakeshin II as the Chalukya ruler who checked Harsha and projected power into the peninsula?

- A. Ravikirti's Aihole inscription
- B. Allahabad pillar inscription
- C. Hathigumpha inscription
- D. Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman

Answer: A. Aihole is the core Chalukya political text for Pulakeshin II.

Learning MCQ 02

The safest way to describe the Pallava origin problem is:

- A. fully solved in favour of a northern foreign line
- B. debated, but securely grounded in Tondaimandalam and Kanchi through inscriptional evidence
- C. impossible because there are no inscriptions
- D. fully solved in favour of a pure Andhra line

Answer: B. The secure core is regional anchoring, not a single ethnic theory.

Learning MCQ 03

What is the most useful exam function of the term brahmadeya?

- A. it identifies only Buddhist villages
- B. it means any tax collection
- C. it identifies land gifted to Brahmanas and opens the social history of grants
- D. it means any temple

Answer: C. The term is central to grants, locality and hierarchy.

Learning MCQ 04

The title Vatapikonda is associated with:

- A. Vikramaditya II
- B. Simhavishnu
- C. Mahendravarman I
- D. Narasimhavarman I

Answer: D. It memorialises the Pallava capture of Vatapi/Badami.

Learning MCQ 05

Which pairing best captures the Pallava architectural sequence?

- A. cave temples -> monolithic rathas -> structural temples
- B. vihara -> chaitya -> mosque
- C. gopura -> minaret -> mandapa
- D. structural -> rock-cut -> stupa

Answer: A. This is the safest exam-ready Pallava trajectory.

Learning MCQ 06

The Durga temple at Aihole is best remembered because it:

- A. marks the founding of the Pala dynasty
- B. is an apsidal and classification-resistant Chalukya monument often linked to Surya/Aditya
- C. was unquestionably dedicated to goddess Durga
- D. is a Pallava port shrine

Answer: B. Its name and cultic identification both require caution.

Learning MCQ 07

Why should the 2024 Pallava PYQ never be answered with monuments alone?

- A. because the question asks only chronology
- B. because literature is absent in the question
- C. because the wording explicitly demands art and literature
- D. because temples are not relevant to the Pallavas

Answer: C. Dandin, Mattavilasa-prahasana and bilingual epigraphy must appear.

Learning MCQ 08

In Sharma's formulation, the Kalabhra revolt is important mainly because it:

- A. founded the eastern Chalukya line
- B. proves all peasant revolts were successful
- C. ended all brahmana settlements permanently
- D. is linked to social-political protest around Brahmana land rights

Answer: D. That is the specific analytical value of the episode.

Learning MCQ 09

Which locality type is trader-merchant dominated in Sharma's south-Indian village triad?

- A. nagaram
- B. mahajana
- C. sabha
- D. ur

Answer: A. nagaram is the trader/merchant settlement form.

Learning MCQ 10

The eastern Chalukyas matter in Topic 23 because they:

- A. built the Brihadishvara temple
- B. show that Pulakeshin II's expansion had durable eastern consequences in Vengi
- C. replace the Pandyas in Madurai
- D. abolish all grant systems

Answer: B. They extend the Chalukya story beyond Badami.

Learning MCQ 11

Which statement about bhakti in Topic 23 is strongest?

- A. it completely erased caste and gender hierarchy
- B. it was only a Sanskrit court movement
- C. it was vernacular devotion with real but limited social opening in a temple-centred world
- D. it belongs only to North India

Answer: C. That is the balanced historical formulation.

Learning MCQ 12

The Virupaksha temple at Pattadakal is especially useful because it combines:

- A. a Chola bronze and a Jain cave
- B. a Buddhist relic chamber and a Mauryan pillar
- C. an Arabic inscription and a gopura
- D. a queen patron, a victory memory and a Dravida superstructure

Answer: D. Lokamahadevi, Kanchi victory and Dravida form make it a high-yield monument.

Learning MCQ 13

Which sentence best captures Upinder's corrective to a crude feudal-fragmentation reading of grants?

- A. grants were one of several integrative and legitimising policies adopted by kings
- B. grants belonged only to the Cholas
- C. grants eliminated all local society
- D. grants always weakened kings

Answer: A. This is the key conceptual correction.

Learning MCQ 14

Kanchipuram's link with Mamallapuram in Upinder's account shows:

- A. only foreign traders shaped the south
- B. hinterland and port outlet were connected through commerce, craft and politics
- C. ports were irrelevant to temple centres
- D. every inland city had no port dependence

Answer: B. That is the correct port-hinterland reading.

Learning MCQ 15

Which statement is safest for "Vesara" in an exam answer?

- A. it is useless and should never be used
- B. it is a fixed official Chalukya self-description
- C. it is a careful modern descriptive label that must follow site-specific evidence
- D. it means any southern temple

Answer: C. Use the label only after describing Aihole-Badami-Pattadakal evidence.

Learning MCQ 16

The best overall label for the Pallava-Chalukya age is:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. This label integrates polity, society and culture.

Objective answers without a secure official key are labelled inferred or route-based. This is deliberate and mandatory.

Workbook MCQ 01

The most secure regional anchor of early Pallava power is:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: A. Tondaimandalam and Kanchi are the secure Pallava regional anchors.

Workbook MCQ 02

Ravikirti is best identified as:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: B. Ravikirti composed the Aihole prashasti of Pulakeshin II.

Workbook MCQ 03

Pulakeshin II is most memorably linked in north Indian history to:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: C. The Narmada check on Harsha is the best-known inter-regional marker.

Workbook MCQ 04

The title Vatapikonda belongs to:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. Narasimhavarman I took the title after the capture of Vatapi.

Workbook MCQ 05

The eastern Chalukya branch emerged in:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: A. Vengi in the Krishna-Godavari zone became the eastern Chalukya base.

Workbook MCQ 06

In Sharma's narrative, the Kalabhra episode is linked most closely to:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: B. The Kalabhra revolt is treated as social-political protest around the established order.

Workbook MCQ 07

Which locality type in the south was dominated by traders and merchants?

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: C. nagaram is the trader-merchant dominated settlement form.

Workbook MCQ 08

In the Chalukya areas, Sharma says rural affairs were managed by village elders called:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. mahajana is the key term highlighted for Chalukya-area village elders.

Workbook MCQ 09

The Sanskrit farce *Mattavilasa-prahasana* is associated with:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: A. It is the most important named literary work directly linked to Mahendravarman I.

Workbook MCQ 10

The best description of Pallava bilingual epigraphy is:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: B. The repository's evidence repeatedly notes this division of labour.

Workbook MCQ 11

The Mamallapuram rathas are most usefully understood as:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: C. Their experimental variety is exactly why they matter.

Workbook MCQ 12

The Durga temple at Aihole should be remembered first as:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. The name is misleading and the cultic identity requires caution.

Workbook MCQ 13

Queen Lokamahadevi is linked with the commission of:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: A. Lokamahadevi commissioned the Virupaksha temple to commemorate Vikramaditya II's success.

Workbook MCQ 14

The Papanatha temple at Pattadakal is especially important because it:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: B. Papanatha and Virupaksha together make the Pattadakal comparison decisive.

Workbook MCQ 15

The Alvars are primarily associated with devotion to:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: C. Alvars are the Vaishnava devotional saints.

Workbook MCQ 16

Who is the only woman in the canonical Alvar list?

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. Andal is the sole woman Alvar.

Workbook MCQ 17

In Upinder's corrective interpretation, brahmadeyas were:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: A. Upinder's position is that brahmadeyas were not merely symptoms of royal weakness, but could serve integrative and legitimising functions.

Workbook MCQ 18

Where brahmadeya villages were situated close to tribal communities, Upinder most clearly suggests:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: B. Upinder's formulation is reciprocal but unequal.

Workbook MCQ 19

Kanchipuram in Upinder's account is especially noted as:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: C. Kanchi's political, commercial and religious significance is threefold.

Workbook MCQ 20

Mamallapuram is best described in relation to Kanchipuram as:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. Upinder makes the port-hinterland link explicit.

Workbook MCQ 21

The secure early Pallava ruler attested in inscriptions before the later revival line is:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: A. He anchors the early inscriptional Pallava line.

Workbook MCQ 22

What does the phrase "under King Bhoja" do in the 2020 chronology PYQ?

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: B. The wording matters because Bhoja belongs later than Gopala.

Workbook MCQ 23

The title of Mahendravarman I's literary text helps the historian chiefly because it:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: C. The historical value of Mattavilasa-prahasana lies in revealing sectarian competition and court culture, not Buddhist supremacy.

Workbook MCQ 24

Which statement about Aihole is strongest?

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. Aihole is architectural and epigraphic at once.

Workbook MCQ 25

The safest statement on Vesara is:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: A. The safest approach is to use Vesara cautiously as a modern descriptive label after monument-first description.

Workbook MCQ 26

Which monument pair best demonstrates side-by-side superstructure contrast at Pattadakal?

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: B. Papanatha versus Virupaksha is the decisive pair.

Workbook MCQ 27

The phrase "purchased peace by ceding their northern provinces" in Sharma refers to:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: C. Sharma uses it for the phase before Pallava recovery under Narasimhavarman I.

Workbook MCQ 28

The later-8th-century shift from rock-cut to structural dominance in Pallava architecture is tied most closely to:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. Rajasimha's phase foregrounds the Shore Temple and Kailasanatha.

Workbook MCQ 29

Which one is the clearest later-Pallava literary memory anchor?

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: A. It is the named Tamil royal biography associated with Nandivarman III.

Workbook MCQ 30

The best concise description of Kanchipuram in Topic 23 is:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: B. That full combination is what makes Kanchi historically important.

Workbook MCQ 31

The capture of Badami by Narasimhavarman I should be interpreted as:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: C. The correct reading is that it was a dramatic but temporary reversal.

Workbook MCQ 32

The strongest line on bhakti and social hierarchy is:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. This is the most balanced and source-sensitive formulation.

Workbook MCQ 33

Which social process is most directly linked by Upinder to the spread of brahmadeya villages near tribal zones?

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: A. That is the most specific process she identifies.

Workbook MCQ 34

The phrase "managaram" in Upinder's description of Kanchipuram helps establish:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: B. The term is used to show Kanchi's urban-commercial importance.

Workbook MCQ 35

Which monument is the best later-Pallava structural marker in Kanchipuram?

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: C. Kailasanatha is the key Kanchi structural temple marker of the Rajasimha phase.

Workbook MCQ 36

The recurring Pallava iconographic theme especially frequent at Kailasanatha is:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. Somaskanda is a signature recurring Pallava motif.

Workbook MCQ 37

In this package, the term "regional state formation" mainly means:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: A. This is the analytical centre of the topic.

Workbook MCQ 38

Which statement on maritime links is safest?

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: B. The safest reading is the evidence-led maritime-link formulation without imperial overclaim.

Workbook MCQ 39

Which title best captures the way new rulers were legitimised in Sharma's account?

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: C. This is how new regional rulers were made respectable.

Workbook MCQ 40

The single best closing sentence for a long answer on Topic 23 would argue that the age:

- A. a pan-Indian empire under one ruler
- B. only an art-history appendix to Gupta India
- C. a simple dynastic war detached from society
- D. the foundational phase of peninsular regional state formation through rivalry, grants, shrines and multilingual court culture

Answer: D. That is the most complete synthetic verdict.

Remedial MCQ 01

Which site-dynasty pairing is correct?

- A. Mamallapuram - Pallava
- B. Badami - Maurya
- C. Pattadakal - Pala
- D. Kanchi - Rashtrakuta

Answer: A. Mamallapuram is securely Pallava.

Remedial MCQ 02

Which statement best corrects a common chronology error?

- A. Vikramaditya II preceded Pulakeshin I
- B. Gopala preceded the rise of the Pratiharas under Bhoja I
- C. Gopala founded the Pala dynasty after Parantaka I
- D. Mahendravarman I ruled after Rajendra I

Answer: B. The wording "under Bhoja" pushes the Pratihara event later than Gopala.

Remedial MCQ 03

What is the safest reading of a prashasti?

- A. temple sculpture in prose form only
- B. neutral annal free of ideology
- C. politically charged praise text with usable historical data
- D. literal census and revenue return

Answer: C. That is exactly how Aihole should be used.

Remedial MCQ 04

Which statement should be avoided in a 2024 Pallava answer?

- A. Mahendravarman I opened the major rock-cut phase
- B. Dandin helps with the literature half
- C. bilingual epigraphy mattered
- D. Pallava contribution can be estimated entirely through architecture

Answer: D. The question explicitly demands both art and literature.

Remedial MCQ 05

Which is the correct caution about local institutions?

- A. ur, sabha and nagaram exist in early evidence, but detailed later Chola machinery should not be back-projected
- B. later Chola sabha committees can be projected backward without evidence
- C. no local institutions existed before the Cholas
- D. mahajana was a Buddhist monastic council

Answer: A. That is the key institutional discipline.

Remedial MCQ 06

What is the best corrective to a one-way Brahmanization narrative?

- A. Brahmanization was only language change
- B. the process was reciprocal but unequal and tied to land, cult and power
- C. there was no hierarchy at all
- D. all tribal groups remained unchanged

Answer: B. This is the most precise conceptual correction.

Remedial MCQ 07

Which monument should be used first to demonstrate the Nagara-Dravida contrast at one Chalukya site?

- A. Sanchi and Bharhut
- B. Brihadishvara and Airavatesvara
- C. Papanatha and Virupaksha at Pattadakal
- D. Shore Temple and Pancha Rathas

Answer: C. The Pattadakal pair is the decisive exam evidence.

Remedial MCQ 08

Which social point about bhakti is safest?

- A. women led the movement everywhere
- B. there were no lower-status saints
- C. bhakti ended temple hierarchy
- D. inclusion narratives exist, but leadership remained overwhelmingly male

Answer: D. That is the balanced line supported by Upinder's discussion.

Semantic-completeness coverage drills - Topic 23

Use each drill as a 60-second plan before returning to the solved PYQs.

Drill	Prompt	Minimum answer route	Fatal trap
A	women led the movement everywhere		
B	there were no lower-status saints		
C	bhakti ended temple hierarchy		
D	inclusion narratives exist, but leadership remained overwhelmingly male		
E	Was Brahmanization one-way cultural replacement?	grant and migration -> status/ritual -> local cult adaptation -> language localization -> unequal reciprocity	homogenization
F	What does multilingual epigraphy prove?	Prakrit/Sanskrit/Tamil/Kannada and bounded Telugu transition -> institutional audience -> literacy limit	language equals ethnicity
G	What can queenly patronage prove?	Lokamahadevi/Virupaksha and Trailokyamahadevi/Mallikarjuna -> elite agency -> no universal gender claim	general equality from two patrons
H	Where does Topic 23 end?	Rashtrakuta takeover c. 753 and continuing Vengi line -> bounded Chola link	all Chalukyas vanish together

Self-check model: every response should contain one named item of evidence, one mechanism, one source or regional limit and one qualified conclusion.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved topic-specific MCQs

Verified PYQ 1 - GS-I Mains 2024 Q2 (exact wording locally preserved)

Estimate the contribution of Pallavas of Kanchi for the development of art and literature of South India. (Answer in 150 words)

Status: Exact wording preserved locally in the official UPSC Mains 2024 GS Paper I.pdf and in the 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The Pallavas of Kanchi were crucial not because they completed South Indian art and literature, but because they initiated a durable early-medieval template that joined court culture, shrine building and multilingual prestige. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Mahendravarman I began the major rock-cut phase at sites such as Mandagapattu and Mamandur and is linked with the Sanskrit farce *Mattavilasa-prahasana*, showing literary as well as artistic patronage. Under Narasimhavarman I Mamalla, the Pancha Rathas and Mamallapuram reliefs turned experimentation in stone into a political landscape. Under Narasimhavarman II Rajasimha, the Shore Temple and Kailasanatha at Kanchi mark the transition to mature structural temples. Pallava literary culture included Kanchi's Sanskrit scholarship, Dandin's court association and bilingual Tamil-Sanskrit inscriptions, which show that literary production and administration were institutionally layered. [LIMIT] Our evidence is heavily monumental and courtly; it does not capture the whole literary field. [VERDICT] The Pallava contribution was therefore foundational: they linked art, language and kingship in a way that later South Indian polities developed further. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, gives named monuments and texts, connects them to what they prove and ends with a graded verdict rather than a list.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Verified PYQ 1 - GS-I Mains 2024 Q2 (exact wording locally preserved)", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Verified PYQ 1 - GS-I Mains 2024 Q2 (exact wording locally preserved)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Verified PYQ 2 - Prelims GS-I 2025 Q14 (exact wording and official Set-A key held locally)

Who among the following rulers in ancient India had assumed the titles Mattavilasa, Vichitrachitta and Gunabhara?

- A. Mahendravarman I
- B. Simhavishnu
- C. Narasimhavarman I
- D. Simhavarman

Official local key status: Set-A official answer key present locally. Correct option: **A. Mahendravarman I.**

Explanation: The titles point to Mahendravarman I, the Pallava ruler associated with early rock-cut patronage, courtly literary culture and the Sanskrit farce *Mattavilasa-prahasana*. The distractors are useful chronology traps: Simhavishnu is the major late-6th-century Pallava consolidator; Narasimhavarman I is Mamalla and Vatapikonda; Simhavarman belongs to an earlier Pallava line and is not the title cluster tested here. **Why this earns marks:** It uses the local official key, explains the title-memory anchor and eliminates each alternative historically.

Routed PYQ 3 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q24 (exact event list preserved locally; official key unavailable)

1. Rise of Pratiharas under King Bhoja
2. Establishment of Pallava power under Mahendravarman I
3. Establishment of Chola power by Parantaka I
4. Pala dynasty founded by Gopala

What is the correct chronological order of the above events, starting from the earliest time?

Status: Original official paper held locally. The stem and event list are readable from the official paper; the option OCR is imperfect, and no official 2020 key is held locally.

Answer / route: INFERRED ORDER - 2 -> 4 -> 1 -> 3.

- Mahendravarman I belongs to the early 7th century.
- Gopala's foundation of the Pala dynasty belongs to the mid-8th century.
- The question specifies the rise of the Pratiharas **under King Bhoja**, i.e. the 9th-century Bhoja phase, not the earliest Pratihara beginnings.
- Parantaka I belongs to the early 10th century.

Why this earns marks: It solves the chronology from the actual wording of the question, especially the phrase "under King Bhoja", while honestly stating that the official key is unavailable locally.

Demand decoding: Treat “Routed PYQ 3 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q24 (exact event list preserved locally; official key...)” as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For “Routed PYQ 3 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q24 (exact event list preserved locally; official key...)”, add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Adjacent PYQ 4 - Prelims GS-I 2026 Q4 (exact wording held locally; provisional key not converted into an official answer here)

Which of the following temples has/have a Nagara-style shikhara?

1. Malegitti Shivalaya, Badami
2. Huchimalligudi Temple, Aihole
3. Dashavatara Temple, Deogarh
4. Virupaksha Temple, Pattadakal

Select the answer using the code given below.

Status: Exact wording preserved locally in the official 2026 Set-A paper. The repository also holds the provisional Set-A key, but the controlling PYQ rule does not record or infer the answer letter from a provisional key. This question is adjacent-owned by Indian Art and Culture Topic 03 and is included here because it directly tests Chalukya architectural discrimination.

Concept route: Deogarh is the obvious Nagara anchor. Virupaksha at Pattadakal is the Dravida side of the Pattadakal pair. The exam discriminators are therefore Badami/Aihole versus Deogarh, which is why Topic 23 must clearly separate site, plan and superstructure instead of using the word "Vesara" loosely. **Why this earns marks:** It teaches the discrimination the question actually tests without pretending that a provisional key is a settled official answer.

Original Mains Practice 01 - 10 marks - 150 words

Explain why the Pallava-Chalukya rivalry mattered more than a mere dynastic war in early medieval peninsular India.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The rivalry mattered because it reorganised political space, not because it produced a simple list of victories and defeats. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Pulakeshin II's Aihole prashasti, Narasimhavarman I's capture of Vatapi, and Vikramaditya II's later Kanchi victories show that warfare shaped frontiers, prestige and succession. The conflict also drove monumental patronage - Mamallapuram, Kailasanatha and Pattadakal were political statements as much as sacred sites. Vengi's emergence from Pulakeshin II's eastern expansion proves that campaigns could create durable secondary states. [LIMIT] Victory claims are highly rhetorical and cannot be read as stable cartography. [VERDICT] The rivalry therefore mattered as an engine of regional state formation, architectural memory and sacred geography. **Why this earns marks:** It moves from war to mechanism, uses named evidence and closes with a reasoned historical significance.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Original Mains Practice 01 - 10 marks - 150 words", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Original Mains Practice 01 - 10 marks - 150 words", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains Practice 02 - 10 marks - 150 words

How far can the term "Brahmanization" explain agrarian and social change in the Pallava-Chalukya age?

Model answer: [CLAIM] Brahmanization explains an important part of the change, but only if used as a political-social process rather than a one-way religious slogan. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Pallava grants, brahmadeya and agrahara settlements, and Sharma's evidence on ur-sabha-nagaram village forms show that rulers redistributed land and revenue to Brahmanas, strengthening hierarchy and locality-making. Upinder adds that brahmadeyas near tribal zones could spread plough agriculture and unequal caste incorporation. [LIMIT] Many grants inserted donees into already settled landscapes, and local/tribal traditions also reshaped Brahmanism. The term "Sanskritization" alone is too narrow because land and power are central. [VERDICT] Thus Brahmanization is useful when qualified by

reciprocity, inequality and agrarian mechanism. **Why this earns marks:** It defines the term, gives evidence, qualifies the concept and avoids teleology.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Original Mains Practice 02 - 10 marks - 150 words”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Original Mains Practice 02 - 10 marks - 150 words”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains Practice 03 - 15 marks - 250 words

Critically evaluate the Aihole inscription as a source for the political history of Pulakeshin II.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The Aihole inscription is indispensable for Pulakeshin II, but it is valuable precisely because it is read critically as a prashasti, not because it is taken literally. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Composed by Ravikirti and dated to Shaka 556 (634-35 CE), it offers the Chalukya genealogy, names early rulers such as Pulakeshin I, Kirtivarman I and Mangalesha, and presents Pulakeshin II's victories across the western Deccan, on the eastern seaboard and against Harsha on the Narmada. It thereby anchors succession, chronology and royal self-image. Its literary ambition also tells us that political legitimacy in the Deccan required Sanskrit cultural display. The inscription's Jain setting further reveals the religious landscape of the court world. [LIMIT] Yet it is not a neutral chronicle. Campaigns are magnified, reversals minimised, and long-term control is not the same as martial success. It does not tell us the Pallava side of the conflict, the peasant cost of campaigning or the exact administrative extent of Chalukya power. Those must be checked against later events, grants, monuments and rival evidence. [VERDICT] Aihole is therefore a first-rank source when used comparatively: it is strongest on royal ideology, genealogy and the event-framework of Pulakeshin's reign, and weakest when pressed into literal territorial cartography. **Why this earns marks:** It answers "critically evaluate" by showing both value and limit, not by merely praising or dismissing the inscription.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Original Mains Practice 03 - 15 marks - 250 words”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Original Mains Practice 03 - 15 marks - 250 words”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains Practice 04 - 15 marks - 250 words

Discuss the shift from rock-cut to structural temples under the Pallavas and Chalukyas without reducing it to a simple linear style history.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The shift from rock-cut to structural temple-building in the peninsula was real, but it was not a neat one-way ladder from crude beginnings to finished perfection. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Under the Pallavas, Mahendravarman I's cave temples at Mandagapattu and Mamandur opened the major rock-cut phase, Narasimhavarman I's Mamallapuram rathas turned stone into monolithic experiment, and Narasimhavarman II Rajasimha's Shore Temple and Kailasanatha at Kanchi foregrounded structural construction. In the Chalukya zone, however, rock-cut and structural forms coexisted: Badami caves continued while Aihole developed structural experiments such as the Lad Khan and Durga temples, and Pattadakal culminated in mature stone temples like

Virupaksha and Papanatha. [ANALYSIS] This proves that technological and ritual experimentation overlapped. Monumental choice depended on patronage, sectarian programme, stone availability, artisanship and political ambition. [LIMIT] Labels like Dravida or Vesara are useful only after the monuments themselves are described. Nor should one assume that every structural advance implies social progress or territorial expansion. [VERDICT] The correct historical reading is therefore not a simple ladder but a phased, regionally varied transition in which technique, cult and kingship changed together. **Why this earns marks:** It supplies named monuments from both dynasties, explains mechanism and includes the label-caution the directive demands.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Original Mains Practice 04 - 15 marks - 250 words”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Original Mains Practice 04 - 15 marks - 250 words”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains Practice 05 - 20 marks - 250 words

Examine how land grants, temple-centred settlement and bhakti contributed to regional state formation in peninsular India c. AD 550-900.

Model answer: [CLAIM] Regional state formation in the peninsula rested on more than warfare; it depended on the embedding of power in land rights, shrines and devotional publics. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Pallava land charters, brahmadeya and agrahara settlements, and the village forms ur, sabha and nagaram show rulers redistributing revenue and jurisdiction in order to anchor authority locally. Upinder's broader interpretation helps explain that grants were not merely evidence of weakness; they could integrate elites, extend cultivation and bind donees to kings. Temples converted this fiscal geography into durable sacred geography. Mamallapuram, Kailasanatha, Aihole, Badami and Pattadakal were not only ritual sites but also political statements in stone. Bhakti deepened the social reach of this order. Alvar and Nayanar hymns created shrine networks, vernacular devotional communities and new emotional ties to specific places. [ANALYSIS] Together, grant, temple and hymn helped transform lineages and campaign states into more regionally rooted polities. [LIMIT] The process was uneven and hierarchical. Many grants inserted Brahmanas into already settled societies; bhakti did not abolish caste or patriarchy; and elite sources dominate the archive. [VERDICT] Even with these limits, the combined evidence shows that locality, devotion and landed power were central to the making of the early medieval south. **Why this earns marks:** It integrates polity, economy, religion and society in one causal chain and ends with a graded judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Original Mains Practice 05 - 20 marks - 250 words”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Original Mains Practice 05 - 20 marks - 250 words”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains Practice 06 - 20 marks - 250 words

Was the Pallava-Chalukya age a foundation stage of the early medieval south? Assess with reference to polity, society, religion, art and maritime links.

Model answer: [CLAIM] Yes, with qualification: the Pallava-Chalukya age was foundational, not because every later institution already existed in finished form, but because the main building blocks of the early medieval south became visible and mutually reinforcing in this period. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Politically, the rivalry between Kanchi and Vatapi created regionally rooted state formations and branching consequences such as Vengi. Socially, land grants, brahmadeya settlements and new locality forms reorganised agrarian society and caste hierarchy. Religiously, Alvar and Nayanar bhakti, temple patronage and sectarian contestation linked sacred space with regional identity. Artistically, the age saw the Pallava transition from cave to monolithic to structural temples and the Chalukya experiment at Aihole-Badami-Pattadakal, with later labels such as Vesara emerging from visible monument practice. Economically, Kanchipuram's weaving and commerce, Mamallapuram's port function and eastern-coast town networks show that agrarian expansion and selective maritime vitality coexisted. [LIMIT] Yet this was still a formative stage. Later Chola inscriptions reveal fuller locality mechanisms, and many subaltern experiences remain indirect in the record. [VERDICT] The age was therefore foundational precisely as a transitional stage: it created the political, social, devotional and monumental frameworks within which the later south would operate more intensively. **Why this earns marks:** It assesses rather than asserts, covers every named dimension and distinguishes foundation from completion.

Final examiner checklist for Topic 23 answers

Use this before closing any long answer or before self-marking a workbook response.

If the answer discusses...	Do not miss
Pallava polity	Simhavishnu, Mahendravarman I, Narasimhavarman I or Rajasimha with one named site or text
Chalukya polity	Pulakeshin II, Aihole/Ravikirti, Narmada check, Vengi consequence or Pattadakal memory
Society / agrarian change	brahmadeya or agrahara, ur-sabha-nagaram, hierarchy and one [LIMIT] line
Religion / bhakti	Alvar-Nayanar devotion plus Jain/Buddhist interaction and social-limit caution
Art / architecture	monument first, style label later; avoid using "Vesara" as a substitute for description
Economy / maritime links	Kanchi-Mamallapuram linkage, port network or trade evidence without overseas-imperial exaggeration

- End with **regional state formation** or **foundational early-medieval transition**, not a monument list.
- If you use the word **Brahmanization**, qualify it as reciprocal but unequal, linked to grants, cults and local society.
- If you cite Aihole, add that it is a **prashasti** and therefore a source of both data and exaggeration.
- If you mention local institutions, do **not** project fully developed later Chola committee structures backward into the 6th-8th centuries.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Original Mains Practice 06 - 20 marks - 250 words", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Original Mains Practice 06 - 20 marks - 250 words", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.